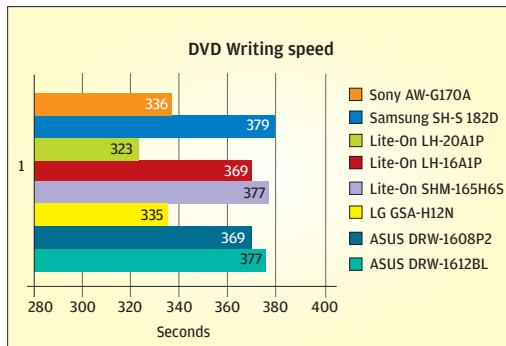


recognised the media as only 16x, and finished the assorted data write test the slowest, at 315 seconds. The Asus DRW-1612BL, which recognised the media as 24x, completed the test in 228 seconds. The LG recognised the media as 48x, and could therefore write the fastest—just 182 seconds.

The 20x-capable drive from Lite-On, the LH-20A1P, sped away in the DVD-R test with 323 seconds and in the DVD+R with 309 seconds. It wrote to the 16x-certified Sony media at 20x for DVD-R and 18x for DVD+R. The Asus drive featuring “overspeeding”, could write to an 8x DVD+R media at 12x last year, and thus proved faster; this time round, the Asus drives, did not prove that



they could indeed “overspeed.”

The Samsung was the slowest in the DVD+R assorted data test. At around 85 per cent, the speed suddenly plunged below 4x, and it took 602 seconds for this drive to complete the burning process. But in the DVD+RW test, this drive emerged the fastest, burning the 700 MB assorted data in just 135 seconds. The Asus DRW-1608P2 was the slowest here with 171 seconds. It was also the only drive that produced coasters. While it could burn assorted data, it failed to burn to sequential DVD-R media. We repeated the test several times but found the same result.

The Verdict

After all that burning and the smoke cleared, we took a look at the prices to help us determine the overall winner in each class of drives.

The Sony CRX320EE had the lowest specified CD-RW writing speeds of 24x as compared to 32x for the rest, yet it could burn a 10x CD-RW at 12x, which saves you a minute and a half. It was the top scorer as far as performance is concerned, exhibiting faster ripping speeds along with the second-fastest writing speeds for CD-R. The Sony CRX320EE, priced the second-lowest, is a deserving winner of the *Digit Best Buy Gold* for Combo drives.

Coming in close was the inexpensive Lite-On SOHC-5232K, which with its average performance, wins the *Digit Best Buy Silver* for Combo drives.

The Lite-On Super AllWrite LH-20A1P, with the highest writing speed to DVD-R in the world—20x, a stellar performance that left the competition biting the dust, and a surprisingly low price of Rs 2,095, was adjudged the winner of the *Digit Best Buy Gold* for DVD-Writers. With equally impressive features—being able to write to all types of media, bundled with two bezels, coming in second in terms of performance, and priced the lowest of

Contact Sheet		Optical Drives	
Brand	Company	Phone	E-mail
ASUS	Asustek Computer Inc	022-40058888	media_india@asus.com
LG	LG Electronics India Pvt Ltd	0120-2560900	response@lgindia.com
Lite-On	Mediatech India Distribution P Ltd	022-26361111	digit@mediatechindia.com
Samsung	Samsung India Electronics P Ltd	011-41511234	hari.pandey@samsung.com
Sony	Rashi Peripherals Pvt Ltd	022-67090814	navinderc@rptechindia.com

the lot at Rs 1,950, the Lite-On Super AllWrite LH-16A1P drafted close behind its sibling and was awarded the *Digit Best Buy Silver* for DVD-Writers.

Final Thoughts

Last year, we had speculated that in 2007, we might see a shootout of Blu-ray and HD-DVD drives. Our speculations have gone all wrong. One of the reasons is the format war, which continues, and with no party ready to back down. The consumer is the one who loses out, because the technology has existed for a considerable period of time, but the manufacturers have decided to hold it back.

Another reason for us not being able to conduct tests of HD-DVD and Blu-ray drives is the scarce availability and the insanely high prices of not just the drives, but also of the media. A Blu-ray drive costs an astronomical Rs 43,000, and the media available now costs an equally ridiculous Rs 1,600!

We love our hardware here at *Digit*, and we're now hoping that we'll get to see the next generation of optical media when we come back to testing optical drives next year. ■

jayesh_limaye@thinkdigit.com

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